



The Burgeoning Field of Gender, Work & Organization: Some thoughts on the 6th Biennial International Conference of the journal Gender, Work and Organisation (GWO2010)

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Abstract

In the last twenty years, the Gender, Work and Organization (GWO) Journal has made a significant contribution towards advancing the field of social science inquiry. As the GWO journal has grown in institutional strength, it has facilitated the organization of a biennial international interdisciplinary conference series, alongside an international workshop programme. Conference themes cover a wide variety of issues in the field of gender, work and organization emerging from recent scholarship in the field. This report is an analysis of what the conference, and its contents, depicts about the field of gender, work and organization in contemporary times. I present an overview of how the field has developed in the last 20 years, followed by an analysis of what the 6th biennial GWO conference suggests about where the field is, where it may be headed, and some consideration for future developments.

Introduction

In the last two decades the field of gender, work and organization has become an important field of study across many social science disciplines such as Sociology, Management, Organisational Analysis, Gender and Women Studies, Diversity, Public Policy, Economics. A “Google scholar search” in 2011 using the phrase “gendered organizations” produced 24,000 sources. Dana Britton and Laura Logan found in 2008, also using Google, 4,660 articles published between 1990 and 2007 using the term “gendered” in their titles, with many concerning “gendered work” and “gendered labor markets.”

Established in 1994 through a coalition of academics studying gender and organizations, the contribution of the Gender, Work and Organizations (GWO) journal toward strengthening the field is undeniable. According to Martin (2010), the increase of feminist academics both men and women spurred “direct and indirect interest in issues of equal opportunity” (p. 2) contributing to the establishment of the GWO journal. Further, the shrinking of sociology departments and the expansion of Management and Business Schools in the 1970s resulted in organizational sociologists moving into Business schools increasing the market for the journal (Martin 2010). The journal grew in circulation and since its recognition from the Institute for Scientific Information (ISI) has a five year impact factor of 1.766, becoming a leading journal to publish gender scholarship in the area of work and organization. One accomplishment of GWO has been the production of research and theory about gender equity. Since the 1980s, GWO scholars have identified conditions and practices that support and prevent gender equality. The journal has published papers that have critically analyzed relationships of women and femininities and men and masculinities with organizations in the context of work.

As the GWO journal grew in institutional strength, it has facilitated the organization of the biennial international interdisciplinary conference series. There have been six conferences to

date with the seventh, GWO2012, in June of 2012. The GWO2010 conference gathering at Keele University, England showcased the work of approximately 467 participants from approximately 43 different nations, 33 academic disciplines and 18 broadly defined themes. Over 330 international colleagues were in attendance to present 303 papers.

The Last Thirty Years: some thoughts on the Field of gender, work and organizations

Gender, work and organization has emerged as a specialty field arguably only in the last few decades, becoming a key analytical category in studies of work and organization in most humanities and social science disciplines. The effort to make gender inequality in the public sphere visible was advanced by the early scholarly works of Epstein (1970), Joan Acker (1973) and Acker and Van Houten (1974). Epstein's (1970) was one of the first scholars to draw attention to the structural factors such as sex-typing of occupations, unwillingness of superiors to pick women protégés among others that affected women's professional performances in "male-establishments" which defined most workplaces at the time. Acker argues in her 1973 article that in our society sex-based inequalities are "salient to the structure of stratification systems" (p. 944). Joan Acker and Donald Van Houten's (1974) strong critique of the famous Westinghouse/Hawthorne wiring room experiments (Crozier 1964) followed this. The authors argued that the researchers failed to take gender into account. They contended that the malleability of workers in the experiments was not only due to the "Hawthorne effect" (as the workers were under special attention from the researchers) but also because the research participants were women. Gender socialization and access to limited resources and opportunities were thought to make women more likely to be easily controlled and more apt to work under poor conditions.

Rosabeth Kanter further analyzed the issue in her landmark book: *Men and Women of the Corporation* (1977), emphasizing the argument that the way women experienced organizations was different from men. Kanter contended that women are used as “tokens” in organizations and have are lower paid and have low opportunity jobs. Structural factors, Kanter argued, shapes women’s position and puts them at a disadvantage within an organization rather than their gender acting as an essential category. Kanter suggested that men would suffer in same ways if they were “tokens” in women-dominated work. While other researchers have later refuted some of her claims, Kanter’s research led gender scholars to turn a keen eye on gender at work and opened the floodgates for a succession of researchers across disciplines on the issue of how all work organizations were gendered.

Through the 1980s, numerous researches (see for example Martin 1980, Pollert 1981, Hearn and Parkin 1983, Greenhaus & Buetell, 1985, Roos 1985, Connell 1987, West and Zimmerman 1987, Cockburn 1988) were published that examined how gender dynamics played out in organizations. Organizational scholars such Baron and Bielby (1985, 1986) pointed to the non-uniform distributions of women and men across jobs, positions, and organizations. Elshtain (1981) and Stacey and Price (1981) critically evaluated the public and private sphere divide and Jeff Hearn and Wendy Parkin (1983) in their landmark article brought sexuality in the workplace to the forefront of academic debates laying the foundations for research on gendered and sexualized management.

The late 80s saw the emergence of a new kind of critical scholarship that critiqued the notion of gender as being a fixed/static, essential and unchangeable demographic category. Instead, gender scholars reframed gender as a process – fluid, variable and changing. This reframing began with the path-breaking article “Doing Gender” by West and Zimmerman (1987) in which the authors argue that the reason people continuously perform gender is due to social

expectations of the gender order. The authors point out how social accountability leads people to dress, behave, gesture in gendered ways such that biological sex categories become irrelevant and gender as a cultural category takes precedence. This makes gender malleable and mutable. R. W. Connell, in her book *Gender and Power* (1987), re-conceptualized the social construction of gender as maintained through gendered practices and practicing. Connell also analyzed the how labor, power and cathexis form the structural features of a gender order and institution, which is sustained through practice. She provided us with a framework for a structural analysis of women's subordination within social and economic institutions.

Gender scholarship in the 1990s continued to build on the body of work already produced but focused on gender and the body and work organizations as gendered institutions. Joan Acker's (1990) influential article, "Hierarchies, Jobs, And Bodies: Toward A Theory Of Gendered Organizations" fiercely critiqued the theoretical assumption of organizational theory that worker are "abstract, bodiless..., who occupies the abstract, gender-neutral job, has no sexuality, no emotions, and does not procreate" (p.151). Acker argued that organizational structure and hierarchies are gendered. She contents that gender is embodied in the worker and jobs they do that assumes men as the ideal abstract workers and women as disruption to the organizational efficiency. Reskin's (1993) article turned our attention to occupational sex-segregation where she argued that while women were entering fields historically occupied by men, they are systematically funneled into gendered occupations, which are often lower paid and lower prestige work within the field. Martin's (1997, 2005) research on rape processing work shows that gender is integral to organizational culture and practices (gendered division of labor) refuting the organizational theory that gender is irrelevant in the workings of an organization. Martin further finds that even when the organizational protocol renders gender irrelevant, processors informally activate gender in their justification accounts. Marta Calas and Linda

Smircich (1991) reinforced the concept of gender embodiment in organizations through a deconstructive frame on “managerial leadership” to reveal its masculine, seductive, and sexually aggressive character, and David Collinson and Jeff Hearn (1997) showed how men “act like men” when doing managerial work by enacting masculinities when managing.

In the last decade, the scholarship on gender, work and organization has paid critical attention to men and masculinities and explored the link between women’s continued disadvantage within work organizations and practicing of masculinities. In 2001, Martin’s article, “ ‘Mobilizing Masculinities: Women’s Experiences of Men at Work’”, explores how men mobilize their masculinities in concerted ways at work, often unintentionally, negatively affecting women’s experiences at work. Martin further argues that men are only liminally aware of the mobilization of masculinities making the gendered practices resulting from it unproblematic and thus unquestionable. She went on to argue (Martin, 2005) that practicing gender, especially masculinities persists because of a lack of reflexivity about gender especially among men. Kristin Schilt’s (2006) work on female-to-male transsexual men in the workplace reveals the persistence of gendered practices in work organizations. Her work shows that women who transition to men command more authority and privilege within organization than when they were women. Furthermore, white and tall female to male transsexuals get more respect and privilege than non-white and shorter female to male transsexuals. Even when trans men and women try to craft alternative femininities and masculinities in the workplace, their co-workers enforce strict gender codes on these transitioning individuals such that they become concerned for their job security and workplace safety (Schilt, 2010).

While masculinities in the work place have found prominence in the last decade, we have fewer researches on femininities in work and organizations. Joyce Fletcher amongst others has done some path-breaking work around femininities in the workplace. Fletcher’s (1999, 2004)

work has shown women's contribution at work is often devalued by labeling it as "just what women do" rather than as instrumentally or technically valuable. One theme for gender scholars' future research may lie in exploring femininities in the workplace, and why organization theorists have seldom studied femininities at work.

Another under theorized area has been the intersection of race and gender in studies of organization and work. Several studies in the last two decades centralize the experiences of non-white women workers but these studies arguably remain on the periphery of organizational theory (Acker 2000, Ibarra 1995, McGuire 2000). However, the range of research presented at the Gender Work Organizations 6th Biennial International Conference in the Summer of 2010 shows that scholars are concerned about the scarcity of theoretical frameworks around femininities and intersectionality.

Insights from the 6th Biennial International Conference:

As a participant in this conference and author of this report, I have had a chance to reflect on the conference both as a participant and a reviewer. As a participant my first experience with the conference began at the Manchester airport where I met three other participants – one from Australia, one from Canada and the other from Turkey. I was traveling from the United States. Our disciplines and our research topics were as diverse as our geo-spatial locations on the globe: we were scholars in sociology, technology, management and global studies and our topics ranged from immigrant women in ethnic labor markets in the U.S. to women employees in banks and financial companies to careers of female and male scientists working in technology transfer.

The overwhelming diversity experienced at the conference, later translated into numbers, for the purposes of this report, tells a compelling story about the field of gender, work and organization as well as the GWO journal. Table 1 provides a summary of the diversity that was

represented at the GWO conference. Besides the large number of individual participants and papers (N=467 and N=306), the conference also included 43 nations and about 33 disciplines and 18 themes. The themes were categorized according to the topics of streams in the conference. The complete data is attached as Appendix 1 and 2. I tabulated the data using the GWO conference brochure and booklet.

Table 1: Summary of Participation at the 6th Biennial GWO International conference

Conference Participation	Total numbers*
Individual Participants	467
Papers Presented	306
Participating nations	43
Disciplines	33**
Topics or Themes	18

***The numbers are to the closest approximation based on the information available from the conference information booklet.**

**** There was no information about discipline available for about 65 participants.**

The largest number of participation in terms of individuals were from England at 126, followed by Australia at 56, Germany at 38, Sweden at 36, USA at 33 and Norway at 24. The rest of the participants were distributed among the remaining 37 countries and ranged between one and eighteen for each country. The disciplines that were included in the conference varied between Management, Business and Law, Sociology, Gender and Women Studies, Human Geography, Humanities and Technology and Health Sciences among others. In terms of the distribution of participants from different disciplines as observed by nations, I found that the most number of papers from England, Australia, Germany and Sweden came from Management, Business and Law and Technology. For England and Australia, Management as a discipline far exceeded all other disciplines as represented through papers and participants. 39% of all papers presented from Australia came from Management and 48% of all papers presented from England came from Management alone and only about 15% for both countries came from Sociology and

Women and Gender Studies combined. In comparison, only 18% of all papers presented from the U.S. were from Management and Business and 33% of the papers came from Sociology and Women and Gender Studies.

The pattern that in countries like England, Australia, Sweden and Germany, scholars of management and business engage in feminist discourse around the study of work and organizations may be either an indication of progressive and equitable politics in the management schools or it may suggest a contraction of Sociology and Gender Studies Departments. The case of United States is particularly interesting. Despite the presence of powerful, well-funded and numerous Management Schools, gender scholarship seems not to be the focus of management studies, as indicated from the basic analysis of the data available from the conference. Gender scholarship seems to be still concentrated within the disciplines of Sociology and Gender and Women Studies in the United States.

Given the diversity of disciplines included in the conference, the themes, topic and type of presentations varied widely. A Swedish group of scholars presented their research in the form of a performance, which was a powerful medium to convey the ideas of institutionalized gender inequity. The broad themes in the conference that canopied several paper topics (Appendix 1) varied from organizing and gender inequity within organizations; to work family conflict, to gender and dirty work; gender and globalization; embodied gender work; femininities and masculinities in organizations; sexual politics in the workplace, gender in organizations in relation to diversity; gender, work and mothering to gender in the academy and several other themes. Each theme included anywhere between 6 to 24 papers. While the papers covered a wide variety of topics and issues related to gender work and organizations, only about six papers out of 306 addressed the issue of race in intersection with gender at work and within organizations. Yet the breadth of the topics and themes at GWO2010, the huge range of disciplines included

and the international outreach of the conference is a testimony to the influence and scholarly importance of the GWO journal.

Conclusion

Participation data from the Gender Work Organizations, 6th Biennial International Conference points to some theoretically and empirically interesting dimensions. The first is that a peer-reviewed academic journal can have a huge impact in shaping a field, and in particular, contributing to the pressure for scholars in Management and Business to think about issues of gender equity. The transnational inclusiveness of the conference and the journal is noteworthy as most journals in the global north publish and engage with scholars who similarly reside and work in the global north (Connell 2007). The data analyzed from the conference also suggests how gender scholarship varies by disciplines among nations. It may be theoretically interesting to examine why the disciplines of management, business and economics in countries like the U.K, Australia, Sweden and Germany are producing scholarship on gender and in the U.S. such scholarship is still restricted mainly to sociology and gender and women's studies. Papers presented at the conference across disciplines showed that gender inequity is still an issue within most organizations and in most work places; scholars in a wide variety of fields are paying attention to the issue and arguing for institutional changes. Some of the papers also indicated the extent to which journals such as GWO, among other groups concerned with research on gender equity have been successful in advancing interest in achieving structural change, especially in countries such as Norway and Sweden which aim toward more 'gender justice' in society.

One area that I found to be at the margins of organizational theory after scanning the last thirty years of literature, as well as the topics and papers presented at the GWO2010 conference, is the under utilization of intersectionality approach in the study of organizations. How gender

intersects with race and class in the context of workplace and organizations remains largely peripheral to organizational theory and hence race, particularly in relation to gender, remains empirically and theoretically under explored.

Given the impact of the GWO journal in the field, I suggest that the GWO community connect and collaborate with other organizations such as the Sociologists for Women in Society (SWS) in the U.S. or other similar groups across the globe to produce effective and much needed engaged scholarship in the field. I would also urge other social science and management and business journals to model themselves on GWO and to be as inclusive of nations and scholarship. The future of the field perhaps lies in transnational collaborations and transnational feminist scholarship in the field of gender, work and organization.

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